WITS AHEAD RESEARCH GROUP

The AHEAD Fortnightly

Issue 2 · 15 October 2026 · Wits School of Education, University of the Witwatersrand

For these two weeks, the question don change from whether universities suppose use AI to how dem go take decision. Minister Buti Manamela tell the Universities South Africa conference say time don reach to comot from talk-talk go decision for teaching and research, and two Wits computer scientists from the RAIL Lab talk say Africa must set im own AI research agenda, no be only to dey use tools wey oda people build. For the same time, universities for abroad dey back away from AI detectors and from the new licence terms wey Turnitin propose, and e remind us say trust and judgement no be wetin you fit hand over to software. For us for Wits AHEAD, na these kind decisions dey build human capability, and this issue dey reach you for thirteen languages.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1

NEWS · 14 OCTOBER 2026 · GLOBAL

Joining up AI across recruitment, retention and alumni relations can close graduation gaps, if it is governed well

Writing for University World News, IREX project director Cameron Mirza argue say universities suppose treat recruitment, retention and alumni relations as one connected, AI supported lifecycle instead of separate systems wey get separate data. E cite Georgia State University chatbot and predictive analytics programme, wey dem credit say e don cut "summer melt" by about 21 percent and don help Black, Hispanic, first generation and low income students graduate for rates wey match or pass di wider student body, but e warn say models wey dem train with historical data fit still entrench di inequities wey dem suppose fix.

> **Why e matter:** For Wits AHEAD pillar on AI and predictive analytics for student success, dis piece na good reminder say early-warning and retention tools go only close equity gap if dem pair am with human oversight and bias testing, na di same governance question Wits AHEAD dey ask for any analytics tool wey e recommend.

University World News · universityworldnews.com · Read am for source

Mirza, C. (2026, October 14). How AI improves student recruitment, retention, advancement. *University World News*. universityworldnews.com/post.php?story=20261014130619431

2

NEWS · 13 OCTOBER 2026 · SOUTH AFRICA

Wits researchers argue Africa must set its own AI research agenda, not just apply others' tools

Two computer scientists for University of di Witwatersrand, Benjamin Rosman and Steve James, wey dey co-direct di Robotics, Autonomous Intelligence and Learning (RAIL) Lab, dey argue say Africa suppose drive artificial intelligence research instead of just dey use tools wey dem build for oda places. Dem point to Deep Learning Indaba, wey don become di world biggest AI summer school, wey bring 1,300 participants go last year gathering for Kigali, and wey dey run im IndabaX programme for 48 out of Africa 54 kontris dis year, plus Wits new Machine Intelligence and Neural Discovery (MIND) Institute, wey bring togeda around 65 academics across computer science, neuroscience, psychology and policy.

> **Why e matter:** For Wits AHEAD pillar on responsible AI, ethics, equity and policy, di warning against Africa becoming just "a place where oda people dey do science" dey speak straight to Wits AHEAD own mission to build African led capability to set AI research questions, no be just to use AI tools wey dem design for oda places.

Times Higher Education · timeshighereducation.com · Read am for source

Luckhurst, G. (2026, October 13). Africa has crucial role in advancing study of AI, say professors. *Times Higher Education*. timeshighereducation.com/news/africa-has-crucial-role-advancing-study-ai-say-professors

3

NEWS · 9 OCTOBER 2026 · UNITED KINGDOM

More universities end Turnitin contracts as concerns mount

Times Higher Education report say Newcastle University and University of Westminster don join University of Southampton to end dia contract wit Turnitin, di plagiarism-detection company, afta Turnitin propose licence changes wey fit make dem use student coursework to train AI tools. Newcastle mention dat data clause direct; Westminster talk say Turnitin plagiarism checker 'largely ineffective' against AI-written text, and dia AI detector get 'a recognised risk of false positives'. Southampton alone pay Turnitin £87,621 for one year, out of student population wey pass 17,000 undergraduates and 8,000 postgraduates.

> **Why e matter:** For Wits AHEAD pillar on responsible AI, ethics, equity and policy, dis matter show say universities dey start to weigh data governance and how reliable AI-detection tools really be against cost, instead of treating plagiarism-checking contract as something wey must dey fixed forever.

Times Higher Education · timeshighereducation.com · Read am for source

Luckhurst, G. (2026, October 9). More universities end Turnitin contracts as concerns mount. *Times Higher Education*. timeshighereducation.com/news/more-universities-end-turnitin-contracts-concerns-mount

RESEARCH AND REPORTS

Prepare students for post-graduation AI judgement challenges

University World News · 9 October 2026 · Pillar 4: Graduate capability and just transitions. For Wits AHEAD pillar on AI, graduate capability, employability and just transitions, dis finding wey show say confident but wrong AI-assisted work fit read as convincing as correct work dey point to professional judgement, no be AI literacy alone, as di capability wey graduates need well-well before dem enter di job market.

Nguyen, P. (2026, October 9). Prepare students for post-graduation AI judgement challenges. *University World News*. universityworldnews.com/post.php?story=20261009115040153

South African minister tells universities to move from AI debate to decisions on teaching and research

South African Government News Agency (SAnews) · 8 October 2026 · Pillar 1: Generative AI in higher education. For Wits AHEAD pillar on generative AI for higher education, as one cabinet minister come dey lay out clear agenda for teaching, assessment and research capacity instead of just general argument, e dey give South African universities clear mandate to act on.

South African Government News Agency. (2026, October 8). *Universities challenged to prepare graduates for AI-driven future*. SAnews. sanews.gov.za/node/84823

Study of students in China, Japan and Mongolia finds access to generative AI does not guarantee it is useful for learning

arXiv (working paper) · 4 October 2026 · Pillar 1: Generative AI in higher education. For Wits AHEAD pillar on generative AI for higher education, di finding say language and local technology conditions, no be connectivity alone, dey decide whether generative AI truly dey help students learn na warning Wits AHEAD dey apply di same way to English-dominant AI tools wey dem dey use across multilingual Southern African campuses.

Li, M., Xie, Q., Enkhtur, A., Chen, L., & Cheng, F. (2026). From access to realized affordances: University students' generative AI engagement across linguistic and sociotechnical contexts. *arXiv*. arxiv.org/abs/2610.05301

FROM THE GROUP

12 Sep 2026 **Doctoral thesis don complete; candidate go graduate for December 2026**
Examiners don accept the corrections wey dem ask for, for one study about distance-learning students wey succeed well well for higher education for East Africa.

12 Sep 2026 **Masters research report don complete with distinction; candidate go graduate for December 2026**
One bibliometric review of data-driven leadership and policy design; next step na doctoral proposal.

THINGS TO READ WEY WE RECOMMEND

Development as Freedom Amartya Sen, Oxford University Press (1999). Di H for AHEAD. Start here.

With best wishes for the fortnight ahead,



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